

INDIVIDUALITY

The successful executive—the leader, the innovator—is the exceptional man. He is **not** a conformist, except in his adherence to his own ideals and beliefs.

A young business executive I met once might well serve as the prototype for the entire breed of case-hardened conformist "organization men" one finds in ever-increasing numbers in the business world today. His clothes, manners, speech, attitudes—and ideas—were all studied stereotypes.

It was obvious that he believed conformity was essential for success in his career, but he complained that he wasn't getting ahead fast enough and asked me if I could offer any advice.

"How can I achieve success and wealth in business?" he asked earnestly.
"How can I make a million dollars?"

"I can't give you any sure-fire formulas," I replied, "but I'm certain of one thing. You'll go much further if you stop trying to look and act and think like everyone else on Madison Avenue or Wacker Drive or Wilshire Boulevard. Try being a nonconformist for a change. Be an individualist—and an individual. You'll be amazed at how much faster you'll

'get ahead.'"

I rather doubt if what I said made much impression on the young man. I fear he was far too dedicated a disciple of that curious present-day hyper orthodoxy, the Cult of Conformity, to heed my heretical counsel. I'm sure he will spend the rest of his life aping and parroting the things he believes, or has been led to believe, are "right" and safe.

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He'll conform to petty, arbitrary codes and conventions, desperately trying to prove himself stable and reliable—but he will only demonstrate that he is unimaginative, unenterprising and mediocre. The success and wealth for which men such as this yearn will always elude them. They will remain